

Note on Ising/Majorana CFT Duality

Yu Liu

April 09, 2026

Abstract

These notes give a concise introduction to the background gauge field language used in the bosonization of Ising and Majorana CFTs. We review $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge fields, spin structures, and the Arf invariant, then catalogue the key partition function data before deriving the fermionization dualities relating Ising CFT and Majorana CFT on the torus (and more generally on closed Riemann surfaces). [1].

Contents

1	Background Gauge Field Language	2
1.1	$\mathbb{Z}_2$ Gauge Field	2
1.1.1	$\mathbb{Z}_2$ Gauge Theory	2
1.1.2	Cup Product	2
1.1.3	Bosonic Partition Function Coupled to Background Field	3
1.2	Spin Structure	3
1.2.1	Definition	3
1.2.2	Arf Invariant	4
1.3	Useful Results Involving the Arf Invariant	4
1.4	Partition Function Data	4
2	Ising/Majorana CFT Fermionization Duality	6
2.1	Ising = Ising/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$ (Kramers-Wannier Duality)	6
2.1.1	The Orbifold	6
2.1.2	Background Gauge Field Formulation	6
2.2	Majorana = (Ising $\otimes$ Arf/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$ (Fermionization)	7
2.3	Ising = Majorana/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$ (Bosonization)	7
2.4	Majorana' = Arf $\otimes$ Majorana	7
2.4.1	Two Dual Majorana CFTs	7
2.4.2	Relation via the Arf Invariant	7
2.4.3	Chiral Symmetry and Anomaly	8
2.5	Majorana' and Ising/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$	8
2.6	Final Comments	8
	Bibliography	9

1 Background Gauge Field Language

The bosonization of Ising and Majorana CFT are commonly written in a background gauge field language. Here we give a brief, nonrigorous introduction.

1.1 $\mathbb{Z}_2$ Gauge Field

1.1.1 $\mathbb{Z}_2$ Gauge Theory

Boundary conditions in the bosonic theory can be understood in a unified way using the language of a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge theory. We introduce a background gauge field

$$A \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2). \quad (1)$$

This object admits several equivalent interpretations:

- as a cohomology class,
- as a flat $\mathbb{Z}_2$ connection,
- as a homomorphism from the fundamental group, $A \in \text{Hom}(\pi_1(\Sigma_g), \mathbb{Z}_2)$.

Concretely, A assigns a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ value to each non-contractible cycle. Choosing a canonical homology basis $\{a_1, b_1, \dots, a_g, b_g\}$, we write

$$A(a_i) = \alpha_i \in \mathbb{Z}_2, \quad A(b_i) = \beta_i \in \mathbb{Z}_2, \quad (2)$$

so the gauge field is completely specified by

$$A = (\alpha_1, \beta_1, \dots, \alpha_g, \beta_g) \in (\mathbb{Z}_2)^{2g}. \quad (3)$$

1.1.2 Cup Product

Given two $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge fields $A, B \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2)$, their cup product is an element

$$A \cup B \in H^2(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2) \simeq \mathbb{Z}_2. \quad (4)$$

On a closed Riemann surface this evaluates to a number:

$$\int_{\Sigma_g} A \cup B \in \mathbb{Z}_2. \quad (5)$$

In terms of the cycle basis, writing $A = (\alpha_i, \beta_i)$ and $B = (\alpha'_i, \beta'_i)$,

$$\int_{\Sigma_g} A \cup B = \sum_{i=1}^g (\alpha_i \beta'_i - \beta_i \alpha'_i) \mod 2. \quad (6)$$

Since $-1 \equiv 1$ in $\mathbb{Z}_2$, this simplifies to

$$\int_{\Sigma_g} A \cup B = \sum_{i=1}^g (\alpha_i \beta'_i + \beta_i \alpha'_i) \mod 2. \quad (7)$$

For the torus T^2 the cup product table is:

$\int_{T^2} A \cup B$	$A_0 = (0,0)$	$A_1 = (1,0)$	$A_2 = (0,1)$	$A_3 = (1,1)$
$A_0 = (0,0)$	0	0	0	0
$A_1 = (1,0)$	0	0	1	1
$A_2 = (0,1)$	0	1	0	1
$A_3 = (1,1)$	0	1	1	0

Table 1: Cup product integral on T^2 for the four $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge fields, computed modulo 2.

1.1.3 Bosonic Partition Function Coupled to Background Field

Partition functions with different boundary conditions of a bosonic theory (or a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ defect-twisted theory) can be understood as coupling to different background $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge fields:

$$Z[A], \quad A \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2), \quad (8)$$

where A specifies the twisting of fields along non-contractible cycles. The conventions are:

- 0 for Periodic Boundary Condition (did not cross a defect),
- 1 for Anti-Periodic Boundary Condition (crossed a defect).

For example, on the torus $\Sigma_1 = T^2$ with cycles (a, b) we write $A = (\alpha, \beta) \in \mathbb{Z}_2 \times \mathbb{Z}_2$, and the four boundary conditions are

$$Z_{P,P} = Z[(0,0)], \quad Z_{P,AP} = Z[(0,1)], \quad Z_{AP,P} = Z[(1,0)], \quad Z_{AP,AP} = Z[(1,1)]. \quad (9)$$

◊ YL: In fact I don't understand why coupling to a gauge field is equal to inserting a Symmetry defect line; nevertheless, the calculational result is the same in partition functions.

1.2 Spin Structure

1.2.1 Definition

Mathematically, a spin structure can be defined via the quadratic refinement of a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge field,

$$\rho : H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2) \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_2. \quad (10)$$

Physically, we simply understand it as specifying the boundary conditions of fermions along the non-contractible cycles. As with the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge field, we assign a label to each cycle:

- 1 for Periodic Boundary Condition (Ramond, R),
- 0 for Anti-Periodic Boundary Condition (Neveu-Schwarz, NS).

Remark

This convention is **opposite** to the bosonic case: there, 0 denotes periodic.

On the torus T^2 , a spin structure determines whether the fermion is periodic or antiperiodic along each cycle:

$$\rho = (\text{a-cycle}, \text{b-cycle}) \in \{\text{AP}, \text{P}\}^2. \quad (11)$$

Two spin structures are related by a background $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge field $A \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2)$ via

$$\rho + A = (\rho_a + A_a \mod 2, \quad \rho_b + A_b \mod 2), \quad (12)$$

which physically corresponds to flipping the fermion boundary condition along cycles where A is nonzero.

1.2.2 Arf Invariant

The Arf invariant is a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ -valued number depending only on the spin structure; it distinguishes “even” from “odd” spin structures. Mathematically it is defined using quadratic refinements acting on basis elements.

On T^2 with standard cycles (a, b) we label spin structures with 0 (AP) and 1 (P). The four spin structures and their Arf invariants are:

Spin structure (ρ_a, ρ_b)	a -cycle	b -cycle	Arf(ρ)
(0, 0)	0	0	0
(1, 0)	1	0	0
(0, 1)	0	1	0
(1, 1)	1	1	1

Table 2: Arf invariants of the four spin structures on T^2 .

1.3 Useful Results Involving the Arf Invariant

Theorem 1.1

Sum over cup products

For all $\mathbb{Z}_2$ gauge fields $s \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2)$:

$$\frac{1}{2^g} \sum_s (-1)^{\int s \cup t} = \begin{cases} 2^g & \text{if } t = 0 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \quad (13)$$

Theorem 1.2

Arf invariant under shifted spin structure

$$\text{Arf}[a + b + \rho] = \text{Arf}[a + \rho] + \text{Arf}[b + \rho] + \text{Arf}[\rho] + \int a \cup b. \quad (14)$$

Theorem 1.3

Sum over spin structures

$$\frac{1}{2^g} \sum_s (-1)^{\text{Arf}(s+\rho) + \text{Arf}[\rho] + \int s \cup t} = (-1)^{\text{Arf}[t+\rho]}. \quad (15)$$

1.4 Partition Function Data

We collect the partition functions with explicit spin structure (fermionic theory) or background gauge field (bosonic theory) together with their character expansions.

Partition Function	Spin Structure	Characters
$Z_{\text{AP}, \text{AP}}$	$Z[(0, 0)]$	$ \chi_0 ^2 + \chi_{1/2} ^2 + \bar{\chi}_0 \chi_{1/2} + \bar{\chi}_{1/2} \chi_0$
$Z_{\text{AP}, P}$	$Z[(0, 1)]$	$ \chi_0 ^2 + \chi_{1/2} ^2 - \bar{\chi}_0 \chi_{1/2} - \bar{\chi}_{1/2} \chi_0$
$Z_{P, \text{AP}}$	$Z[(1, 0)]$	$2 \chi_{1/16} ^2$
$Z_{P, P}$	$Z[(1, 1)]$	0

Table 3: Partition functions and characters for Majorana CFT.

Partition Function	BG Gauge Field	Characters
$Z_{P,P}$	$Z[(0,0)]$	$ \chi_0 ^2 + \chi_{1/2} ^2 + \chi_{1/16} ^2$
$Z_{P,AP}$	$Z[(0,1)]$	$ \chi_0 ^2 + \chi_{1/2} ^2 - \chi_{1/16} ^2$
$Z_{AP,P}$	$Z[(1,0)]$	$\bar{\chi}_0\chi_{1/2} + \bar{\chi}_{1/2}\chi_0 + \chi_{1/16} ^2$
$Z_{AP,AP}$	$Z[(1,1)]$	$-\bar{\chi}_0\chi_{1/2} - \bar{\chi}_{1/2}\chi_0 + \chi_{1/16} ^2$

Table 4: Partition functions and characters for Ising CFT.

2 Ising/Majorana CFT Fermionization Duality

The Ising CFT and Majorana CFT are related by a web of dualities. We use the torus partition function as an illustrative example; the dualities are claimed to hold on general closed Riemann surfaces.

2.1 Ising = Ising/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$ (Kramers-Wannier Duality)

2.1.1 The Orbifold

This duality is a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ orbifold exchanging the A-series and D-series in the minimal model classification. For the Ising CFT it corresponds to the Kramers-Wannier duality, which relates the partition function of the low-temperature phase to that of the high-temperature phase. Since the A-series and D-series are isomorphic for the Ising model, the orbifold gives a transformation between two isomorphic theories.

The traditional perspective proceeds in two steps:

1. **Project** the theory onto the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ -even Hilbert space:

$$Z \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}(Z_{P,P} + Z_{P,AP}). \quad (16)$$

2. **Restore** modular invariance by adding the $\mathbb{Z}_2$ -twisted sector Hilbert space:

$$+ \frac{1}{2}(Z_{AP,P} + Z_{AP,AP}). \quad (17)$$

This gives the same partition function as the Ising CFT with PP boundary conditions:

$$Z_{\text{orb}} = \frac{1}{2}(Z_{P,P} + Z_{P,AP} + Z_{AP,P} + Z_{AP,AP}) = Z_{P,P}. \quad (18)$$

2.1.2 Background Gauge Field Formulation

Theorem 2.1

$$\text{Ising} = \text{Ising}/\mathbb{Z}_2$$

Coupling to a background gauge field A , the partition functions of the two theories are related by

$$Z_{\text{Ising}/\mathbb{Z}_2}[A] = \sum_{a \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2)} Z_{\text{Ising}[a]} (-1)^{\int a \cup A}. \quad (19)$$

Example. For $A = (0, 0)$:

$$Z_{\text{Ising}/\mathbb{Z}_2}[(0, 0)] = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{a \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2)} Z_{\text{Ising}[a]} = Z_{\text{Ising}}[(0, 0)]. \quad (20)$$

For $A = (0, 1)$:

$$\begin{aligned} Z_{\text{Ising}/\mathbb{Z}_2}[(0, 1)] &= \frac{1}{2}(Z_{\text{Ising}}[(0, 0)] + Z_{\text{Ising}}[(0, 1)] - Z_{\text{Ising}}[(1, 0)] - Z_{\text{Ising}}[(1, 1)]) \\ &= Z_{\text{Ising}}[(0, 1)]. \end{aligned} \quad (21)$$

One can verify from these calculations that the two theories are isomorphic.

◇ YL: In fact I don't understand how to define a dual symmetry and the partition function with a symmetry defect line inserted.

2.2 Majorana = (Ising $\otimes$ Arf/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$ (Fermionization))

Theorem 2.2

$$\text{Majorana} = (\text{Ising} \otimes \text{Arf}/\mathbb{Z}_2)$$

$$Z_{\text{Majorana}[A+\rho]} = \frac{1}{2^g} (-1)^{\text{Arf}[\rho]} \sum_{a \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2)} Z_{\text{Ising}[a]} (-1)^{\text{Arf}[a+\rho] + \int a \cup A}. \quad (22)$$

Example. Take $A = 0$ and fix the spin structure $\rho = (0, 0)$ (two NS boundary conditions). Since $\text{Arf}[(0, 0)] = 0$, the sign $(-1)^{\text{Arf}[a+\rho]}$ equals -1 only for $a = (1, 1)$. Therefore:

$$\begin{aligned} Z_M[(0, 0)] &= \frac{1}{2} (Z[(0, 0)] + Z[(1, 0)] + Z[(0, 1)] - Z[(1, 1)]) \\ &= |\chi_0|^2 + |\chi_{1/2}|^2 + \bar{\chi}_0 \chi_{1/2} + \bar{\chi}_{1/2} \chi_0. \end{aligned} \quad (23)$$

This matches the expected result from the Majorana partition function table exactly.

2.3 Ising = Majorana/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$ (Bosonization)

Theorem 2.3

$$\text{Ising} = \text{Majorana}/\mathbb{Z}_2$$

$$Z_{\text{Ising}[A]} = \frac{1}{2^g} (-1)^{\text{Arf}[A+\rho] + \text{Arf}[\rho]} \sum_{a \in H^1(\Sigma_g, \mathbb{Z}_2)} Z_{\text{Majorana}[a+\rho]} (-1)^{\int a \cup A}. \quad (24)$$

Example. Take $A = (0, 0)$:

$$\begin{aligned} Z_I[(0, 0)] &= \frac{1}{2} (Z_M[(0, 0)] + Z_M[(1, 0)] + Z_M[(0, 1)] + Z_M[(1, 1)]) \\ &= |\chi_0|^2 + |\chi_{1/2}|^2 + |\chi_{1/16}|^2. \end{aligned} \quad (25)$$

2.4 Majorana' = Arf $\otimes$ Majorana

2.4.1 Two Dual Majorana CFTs

One can define a dual theory when considering the Ramond sector of Majorana CFT. When computing the partition function in the Ramond sector, there is a freedom in choosing the fermion parity assignment for the two degenerate ground states $|\sigma\rangle$ and $|\mu\rangle$:

- $(-1)^F |\sigma\rangle = +|\sigma\rangle$ and $(-1)^F |\mu\rangle = -|\mu\rangle$,
- $(-1)^F |\sigma\rangle = -|\sigma\rangle$ and $(-1)^F |\mu\rangle = +|\mu\rangle$.

In principle these two choices define two different theories, yet they share the same torus partition function since it does not matter which state is labeled even or odd.

2.4.2 Relation via the Arf Invariant

The two theories are related by the Arf invariant partition function (also called the Kitaev chain [2]).

Theorem 2.4

$$\text{Majorana}' = \text{Arf} \otimes \text{Majorana}$$

$$Z_{\text{Majorana}'[A+\rho]} = (-1)^{\text{Arf}[A+\rho]} Z_{\text{Majorana}[A+\rho]}. \quad (26)$$

This relation is trivially consistent: changing the fermion parity does not change the partition function of Majorana CFT. Indeed, the only nonzero Arf invariant on T^2 occurs for spin structure $(1, 1)$, where the partition function is already zero.

2.4.3 Chiral Symmetry and Anomaly

One can show that the two theories are related by a chiral transformation. Although chiral symmetry is a classical symmetry, it carries an anomaly that produces exactly:

$$Z[\rho] \rightarrow Z[\rho] \times (-1)^{\text{Arf}[\rho]}. \quad (27)$$

See [1] for a detailed explanation.

2.5 Majorana' and Ising/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$

From the relations above together with mathematical properties of the Arf invariant and the cup product integral, one can prove that Majorana' and Ising/ $\mathbb{Z}_2$ satisfy the same duality of partition functions as Ising CFT and Majorana CFT [3].

Chiral anomaly and Kramers-Wannier duality. This shows that the chiral anomaly on the Majorana side becomes the Kramers-Wannier duality on the Ising side.

2.6 Final Comments

All the results above are established in [1]. They follow from a “seed duality” which is not proved in that paper but appears to be a long-known result; the proof seems to appear in a mathematical literature.

◇ YL: I have no idea why the Arf invariant is identical to the Kitaev chain. Moreover, I don't quite understand the dual symmetry generated after gauging a symmetry, nor how gauging the dual symmetry returns one to the original theory.

Bibliography

- [1] A. Karch, D. Tong, and C. Turner, “A Web of 2d Dualities: Z2 Gauge Fields and Arf Invariants,” *SciPost Physics*, vol. 7, no. 1, p. 7, 2019, doi: [10.21468/SciPostPhys.7.1.007](https://doi.org/10.21468/SciPostPhys.7.1.007).
- [2] A. Y. Kitaev, “Unpaired Majorana Fermions in Quantum Wires,” *Physics-Uspekhi*, vol. 44, no. 10S, pp. 131–136, 2001, doi: [10.1070/1063-7869/44/10S/S29](https://doi.org/10.1070/1063-7869/44/10S/S29).
- [3] S.-H. Shao, “What's Done Cannot Be Undone: TASI Lectures on Non-Invertible Symmetries.” 2024.